



Publisher's Resource Guide

Essential Identifiers Every Independent Publisher Should Know

Prepared by Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing LLC

A Note From the Publisher

When I launched Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing, I spent a lot of time piecing together information from a dozen different sources trying to figure out what I actually needed, and in what order. Nobody handed me a roadmap. This guide is the resource I wish someone had put in my hands at the beginning.

Whether you're preparing your first title or building the infrastructure for a multi-title catalog, these identifiers are not optional extras. They are the foundation your publishing operation stands on. My goal with this handout is simple: walk away today knowing exactly what each one is, why it matters, and where to go to get it.

— **Barbara J. Ratliff** Founder & Publisher, Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing LLC

1. BUSINESS DOMAIN & PROFESSIONAL EMAIL

What It Is

A dedicated internet domain (e.g., jackrabbitpunkinpublishing.com) paired with professional email addresses that match that domain. This is typically one of the first things you set up, because it becomes your identity across every application, portal, and business relationship that follows.

Why It Matters

- **First Impressions:** When you reach out to a library acquisitions team, a distributor, or a reviewer, a gmail.com address signals hobby. A domain-matched email signals business. That distinction opens doors.
- **Operational Hub:** Every account you create (Bowker, IngramSpark, the Library of Congress portal, the Copyright Office) should be tied to your business email. It keeps everything organized and protects you if you ever need to demonstrate business continuity.
- **Brand Consistency:** Your domain name should match your publishing imprint as closely as possible. Once set, it anchors your brand across every channel.

Cost: Annual renewal fees vary by domain registrar and email hosting provider. Expect modest recurring costs.

2. EMPLOYER IDENTIFICATION NUMBER (EIN)

What It Is

An EIN is a nine-digit number assigned by the Internal Revenue Service that identifies your business as a distinct legal and tax entity. Think of it as your company's Social Security number.

Why It Matters

- **Separation of Business and Personal:** Operating under an EIN keeps your personal finances legally distinct from your business operations. This is not a technicality; it is essential protection.
- **Banking:** No EIN, no business bank account. Every legitimate financial institution requires one before they will open a commercial account in your company's name.
- **Paying Contractors:** When you hire a cover designer, editor, or illustrator, you'll need your EIN to issue proper tax documentation at year's end. This is standard operating procedure in professional publishing.

Cost: Free. Apply directly through the IRS website and receive your number immediately upon approval.

Official Source: <https://www.irs.gov>

3. D-U-N-S NUMBER (DATA UNIVERSAL NUMBERING SYSTEM)

What It Is

A D-U-N-S number is a nine-digit identifier issued by Dun & Bradstreet that establishes your business as a verified entity in global commercial databases. It is widely used across the business world, not just in publishing, as a standard credential for proving your company's legitimacy.

Why It Matters

- **Credibility with Distributors:** Print-on-demand platforms, wholesale distributors, and commercial suppliers often reference D-U-N-S records when evaluating new vendor relationships. Having one signals that your company is real and operational.
- **Business Credit:** Your D-U-N-S number anchors a separate commercial credit profile for your publishing company, independent of your personal credit history.
- **Grants and Institutional Opportunities:** Certain grant programs, educational contracts, and institutional partnerships require a D-U-N-S number as part of their application process.

Cost: Free for standard registration through Dun & Bradstreet's official portal.

Official Source: <https://www.dnb.com>

4. ISBN & RETAIL BARCODES

What It Is

The ISBN (International Standard Book Number) is the 13-digit identifier that distinguishes every unique edition of a book in the global marketplace. Hardcover, paperback, ebook, audiobook: each format gets its own ISBN. The barcode printed on a book's back cover is simply a scannable version of this number, often with a 5-digit price extension embedded in it.

Why It Matters

- **Publisher of Record:** This is the one that catches independent publishers off guard. If you accept a “free” ISBN from a platform like Amazon KDP, that platform becomes the Publisher of Record on your title, not you. That locks your book out of traditional brick-and-mortar trade channels. Buy your own ISBNs. Own your titles.
- **Distribution Infrastructure:** Wholesalers, retailers, and library systems all use ISBNs to route and track inventory. Without a proper ISBN registered to your imprint, your book simply does not flow through those channels.
- **Retail Barcodes:** National retail chains require price-extended barcodes on physical books. Missing this detail can cause a title to be automatically rejected by inventory management systems.

Cost: ISBNs are purchased through Bowker in the U.S. A single ISBN runs approximately \$125; a block of 10 is approximately \$295. Buy in blocks because you will use them.

Official Source: <https://www.myidentifiers.com>

5. LCCN: LIBRARY OF CONGRESS CONTROL NUMBER

What It Is

An LCCN is a permanent catalog control number assigned by the Library of Congress. It links your book to its official bibliographic record within the national library system and signals to librarians everywhere that your title has been cataloged at the federal level.

Why It Matters

- **Library Acquisition:** Public libraries and academic libraries use LCCN records to acquire, shelve, and catalog books. Without one, the process of getting your title into a library collection becomes significantly more complicated for everyone involved, including the librarian who wants to carry your book.
- **Professional Legitimacy:** The LCCN printed on a copyright page is one of those details that tells experienced readers and industry professionals that a publisher knows what they are doing.
- **Educational Market:** School districts and university libraries frequently reference LCCN data when processing orders and building collections.

Cost: Free through the Library of Congress Preassigned Control Number (PCN) Program. IMPORTANT: You must apply before your book's commercial release date. This is not retroactive.

Official Source: <https://www.loc.gov>

6. PCIP DATA: PUBLISHER'S CATALOGING-IN-PUBLICATION

What It Is

PCIP data is the block of standardized catalog metadata printed on the copyright page of a professionally published book. It includes subject headings, classification codes, and indexing strings that allow library systems to catalog an incoming book in minutes rather than hours.

Why It Matters

- **Library Compatibility:** The Library of Congress only provides its full CIP service to large traditional publishers. Independent presses obtain PCIP data through professional catalogers. With proper PCIP data in your copyright page, a librarian can drop your book straight into their local system without delay.

- **Discoverability:** PCIP data includes accurate Dewey Decimal classifications and Library of Congress Subject Headings. These are the terms that determine whether your book surfaces when a patron searches a library database.

Cost: \$65 – \$145 through independent professional library catalogers. File for your LCCN first, as most catalogers require it before they can finalize your PCIP block.

7. COPYRIGHT REGISTRATION

What It Is

Copyright registration is the formal act of recording your ownership of a creative work with the U.S. Copyright Office. Your work is technically protected the moment you create it, but registration is what makes that protection enforceable in federal court.

Why It Matters

- **Legal Standing:** You cannot pursue an infringement claim in federal court without a registered copyright. Registration is the prerequisite.
- **Statutory Damages:** If you register within 90 days of publication and someone infringes your work, you are eligible to pursue statutory damages and attorney's fees, not just actual damages. This is a significant legal distinction.
- **Rights Transactions:** Translation rights, film options, licensing deals, and foreign distribution agreements all require clear, documented proof of ownership. Your copyright registration is that proof.

Cost: \$45 – \$65 depending on registration type. File electronically through the Copyright Office portal.

Official Source: <https://www.copyright.gov>

8. SAN (STANDARD ADDRESS NUMBER)

What It Is

A SAN is a unique seven-digit identifier, issued through the same Bowker system that issues ISBNs, that identifies one specific physical business address within the publishing supply chain. It tells distributors, wholesalers, and libraries exactly where an order, invoice, or return should go.

Why It Matters

- **Distributor & Wholesaler Accounts:** IngramSpark and other wholesale accounts frequently reference your SAN alongside your ISBN prefix when setting up electronic ordering.
- **Order Accuracy:** A SAN eliminates confusion when a bookstore, library, or wholesaler places an order electronically, ensuring it reaches the correct business address and account.
- **Industry Standard:** SANs are required for BISAC EDI-based ordering systems such as PUBNET and X*NET, which many established retailers and libraries rely on.

Cost: Approximately \$150, one-time, through Bowker.

Official Source: <https://www.myidentifiers.com>

9. TRADEMARK REGISTRATION

What It Is

A trademark protects your publishing imprint's name, logo, and, optionally, your series titles from being used by another company. It is distinct from copyright: copyright protects the content you create, while trademark protects the brand identity your readers come to recognize.

Why It Matters

- **Brand Protection:** Without a registered trademark, another business could legally use a confusingly similar name, undermining the reputation you have built.
- **Series & Imprint Value:** As your catalog grows, recognizable series names and your imprint mark become assets in their own right, worth protecting the same way you protect a book's copyright.
- **Nationwide Priority:** Federal registration through the USPTO establishes nationwide rights and priority, rather than relying on the more limited protection of common-law use.

Cost: \$350 per class of goods/services (USPTO base filing fee), plus optional attorney fees.

Official Source: <https://www.uspto.gov>

10. SELLER'S PERMIT / SALES TAX ID

What It Is

A state-issued permit, sometimes called a resale certificate or sales tax license, that authorizes your business to collect sales tax on direct-to-consumer sales and to purchase inventory at wholesale without paying tax on it yourself.

Why It Matters

- **Direct Sales:** If you sell books directly, at events, through your own website, this permit is what makes those sales legal and lets you remit the tax you collect properly.
- **Wholesale Purchasing:** Printers, distributors, and suppliers will often ask for your resale certificate before selling you inventory tax-free.
- **Compliance:** Operating without one, once you have taxable sales, can expose your business to penalties.

Cost: Varies by state; commonly free to \$100. Filed through your state's Department of Revenue (or equivalent).

11. DBA / FICTITIOUS BUSINESS NAME FILING

What It Is

If your publishing imprint operates under a name different from your LLC's legal registered name, most states require you to file a "Doing Business As" (DBA), also called a fictitious name or trade name filing.

Why It Matters

- **Legal Operation:** Banks, distributors, and government agencies generally require a DBA on file before they will let you operate, invoice, or bank under an imprint name that differs from your legal entity name.
- **Brand Flexibility:** A DBA lets you publish, market, and bank under your imprint name while your LLC's legal paperwork stays simple underneath.

Cost: Typically \$10 – \$100, filed at the state or county level.

12. BUSINESS & MEDIA LIABILITY INSURANCE

What It Is

Insurance coverage designed for publishers, protecting against claims like defamation, invasion of privacy, and copyright or trademark infringement, risks that standard general liability policies often exclude.

Why It Matters

- **Claim Protection:** A single dispute, over a quote, a cover image, or a claim of defamation, can be costly to defend even when you ultimately prevail. Media liability coverage protects against that cost.
- **Distributor Requirements:** Some large distributors and institutional buyers require proof of insurance before entering a vendor relationship.
- **Peace of Mind:** As your catalog grows, so does your exposure. Coverage scales with your business rather than becoming an emergency expense later.

Cost: Varies by provider and coverage level; typically several hundred dollars per year for a small press.

QUICK-REFERENCE COST GUIDE

Use the table below as a fast reference when planning your publishing infrastructure budget.

Identifier / Element	Primary Purpose	Typical Cost	Source
Business Domain & Email	Brand Identity & Legitimacy	Varies by provider	Domain Registrars / Email Hosts
EIN	Business Tax Identification	Free — IRS.gov	IRS.gov Portal
D-U-N-S Number	Global Corporate Credentialing	Free — Dun & Bradstreet	DNB.com Portal
ISBN (Single)	Individual Title/Edition ID	~\$125 per single	MyIdentifiers.com (Bowker)
ISBN Block (10 Pack)	Scalable Catalog Footprint	~\$295 per 10-pack	MyIdentifiers.com (Bowker)
LCCN / PCN	National Library Catalog Record	Free — must file pre-release	LOC.gov Portal
Professional PCIP Data	Library Database Classification	\$65 – \$145	Independent Library Catalogers
Copyright Registration	Federal IP Protection	\$45 – \$65 (by file type)	Copyright.gov Portal
SAN (Standard Address Number)	Distributor & Order Routing ID	~\$150 one-time	MyIdentifiers.com (Bowker)
Trademark Registration	Brand Name & Logo Protection	\$350+ per class (USPTO)	USPTO.gov
Seller's Permit / Sales Tax ID	Direct Sales Tax Compliance	Free – \$100, varies by state	State Dept. of Revenue

Identifier / Element	Primary Purpose	Typical Cost	Source
DBA / Fictitious Name Filing	Legal Use of Imprint Name	\$10 – \$100, varies by state/county	State / County Clerk
Business & Media Liability Insurance	Publisher Risk Protection	Varies by provider / coverage	Insurance Broker (Media/Publishing)

RECOMMENDED SETUP SEQUENCE

Order matters. Following this sequence avoids data conflicts and ensures each identifier is in place before the next one requires it.

1. **Establish Your Business Entity:** Formally incorporate your LLC or publishing company through your state.
2. **File a DBA (If Needed):** If your imprint name differs from your LLC's legal name, file a Doing Business As with your state or county before opening accounts under that name.
3. **Secure Your Domain & Business Email:** Establish your digital presence and use your business email on every application that follows.
4. **Obtain Your EIN:** Apply through IRS.gov. Required before you can open a business bank account.
5. **Register for a D-U-N-S Number:** Establish your commercial credentialing through Dun & Bradstreet.
6. **Register Your Trademark:** Protect your imprint name and logo through the USPTO before your brand gains wider recognition.
7. **Obtain Your Seller's Permit:** Register with your state to collect sales tax on direct sales and purchase inventory at wholesale.
8. **Purchase Your ISBN Block:** Buy through Bowker using your exact legal business name. Do not accept platform-issued ISBNs.
9. **Register Your SAN:** Obtain your Standard Address Number through Bowker to support wholesale and distributor ordering accounts.
10. **File for Your LCCN:** Register your title through the Library of Congress PCN Program before its release date.
11. **Commission Your PCIP Data:** Provide your assigned LCCN to a professional cataloger to generate the copyright page data block.
12. **Secure Business & Media Liability Insurance:** Put coverage in place before, not after, your first dispute.
13. **Set Up Distribution Channels:** Connect your ISBNs and banking to wholesale platforms such as IngramSpark and Amazon KDP.
14. **Register Your Copyright:** Submit to the U.S. Copyright Office within 90 days of publication.
15. **Launch Strategic Outreach:** Begin library, school, and retail campaigns backed by a fully credentialed catalog, including advance reader copies distributed through platforms like NetGalley or BookSirens.

“Publishing a book is a creative achievement. Building a publishing house is an infrastructure decision. These credentials are what separate a title from a catalog and a moment from a legacy.”

— Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing LLC

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